

Adapting Journalism for Gen-Z in Nepal Using Short-Form Content

1st Yunidh Rawal

*Department of Computer Science and Engineering
Kathmandu University
Dhulikhel, Nepal
ryunidh@gmail.com*

2nd Mukul Aryal

*Department of Computer Science and Engineering
Kathmandu University
Dhulikhel, Nepal
aryalmukul@gmail.com*

3rd Prayash Shakya

*Department of Computer Science and Engineering
Kathmandu University
Dhulikhel, Nepal
prayashshakya20@gmail.com*

4th Anupama Neupane

*Department of Computer Science and Engineering
Kathmandu University
Dhulikhel, Nepal
anupaneupane1994@gmail.com*

Abstract—Recent popularity of short-form content platforms has created a revolutionary shift in the digital landscape, where industries like journalism are struggling to keep up with modern trends. In Nepal, the journalism industry is struggling to engage younger audiences with traditional forms of content delivery. This paper explores short-form content based adaptation strategies for journalism to increase news consumption and engagement for Gen-Z (Generation Z), the generation of people born between the mid-1990s and early 2010s. A survey of 110 respondents revealed significant interest in short-form news delivery, with 75% using social media as their primary news source. A prototype mobile application was developed featuring a scrolling-based user interface inspired by short-form content platforms. The findings of this research emphasize the potential of short-form news aggregation to revitalize journalism.

Index Terms—short-form content, gen-Z, digital journalism, news aggregation

I. INTRODUCTION

Journalism in Nepal is going through a significant digital transformation as traditional media like print journalism and televised news struggles to remain relevant in a landscape that is rapidly evolving. In recent years, modern online platforms like TikTok, Instagram, Facebook and YouTube have revolutionized the internet by introducing and popularizing short-form content. Especially among younger audiences, short-form content is an extremely popular form of sharing and interacting with information. This paper examines the potential of short-form content to engage Gen-Z in Nepal and its implications for journalism's future.

The decline of legacy media, combined with the rapid adoption of mobile internet has created an urgent need for digital adaptation strategies. This study aims to bridge the gap by identifying content preferences and designing a prototype mobile application that aligns with the habits of Gen-Z. By utilizing survey data and usability feedback, this research provides actionable insights into creating a sustainable digital journalism model.

II. LITERATURE REVIEW

A. The Decline of Legacy Media

Legacy media are the mass media institutions that dominated the landscape of information and news prior to the internet. In the context of Nepal, media like newspapers, radio broadcasts and television channels were dominant forces before mass adoption of internet. According to Nepal Media Survey 2024 conducted by Sharecast Initiative (N=4267), with a sample size consisting of people from various demographic backgrounds all over the country, 62% of participants said they used Facebook and 44% of participants said they used YouTube to consume news. Whereas only 21% used TV and 5.3% used Newspapers to consume news [1]. The data is clear, with the rise of digital landscape in Nepal and more people gaining access to stable internet connections, social media is the new dominating platform for media.

B. Challenges in Nepalese journalism

Traditional newsrooms used to be the heart of journalism, where important news was produced and journalistic values were maintained. But with the rise of digital media like online news and social media, these traditional pillars of journalism are being challenged. Journalists, especially in developing countries like Nepal, are struggling to adapt because most of them came from traditional media backgrounds and lack digital skills. It is a struggle for them to maintain quality journalism while learning new digital skills. Some traditional outlets like Gorkhapatra and Kantipur are slowly adding digital features, while some stick mainly to traditional methods. Platforms like OnlineKhabar and Setopati are going fully digital to keep up with modern trends [2].

The main challenge is finding ways to engage younger audiences (Gen-Z) while maintaining journalistic standards and financial stability in this digital transition. Globally, the recurrent decline of newspaper circulation and the shrinking

of print advertisement revenue are critical issues that news agencies are fighting with in order to survive and sustain themselves in the current digital market [3].

C. Impact of Short-Form Content

Short videos are an audiovisual content format that typically last between 15 seconds and three minutes [4]. This type of content has gained popularity on social networks due to its ability to convey information quickly and attractively, adapting to mobile consumption and limited user attention [5]. The success of platforms such as TikTok, Instagram and Facebook (Reels) and YouTube (Shorts) highlights the importance of short videos in managing communication in the social media landscape [6].

Given this, it is essential that organizations, especially those in the media sector, adapt to new trends and explore the potential of short-form content on social networks as a form of communication management to optimize resources [7]. This will allow them to gain reach in the digital space and generate more revenue.

D. Digital Adaptation Strategies in Other Markets

A study on impact of short videos on digital journalism in social media analyzed the performance of four Portuguese media outlets regarding the use of short videos on social media, with the aim of understanding their management of communication on social media and audience engagement. Considering the analysis carried out in 2023, there was an increase in the number of followers in all the newspapers [8].

Journalism is undergoing significant technological disruption, with platforms like TikTok influencing production, distribution, and consumption of news. TikTok's unique algorithm and short-form content format have redefined how news outlets engage with younger audiences, especially Gen-Z. A study that analyzed 19 verified news media TikTok accounts from a database of 234 global profiles found that these media outlets successfully used TikTok to connect with younger audiences, promoting their brand identity while adapting to the platform's visual and interactive logic [9].

III. METHODOLOGY

The methodology for our study adopts a **design-based research** approach, involving iterative cycles of design, testing, analysis and refinement. We are still in early iterative cycles, with more possibility for refinement in the future.

A. Initial Data Collection Survey

To understand news and short-form content consumption habits among Gen-Z audience, we conducted an initial survey among our peers based on **convenience sampling**. While initially the survey was only meant for Gen-Z audience, we got some data from older generations as well.

The survey consisted of 15 questions and we received 110 total responses. It contained a mix of qualitative and quantitative questions which aimed to get data about news and short-form content consumption habits and preferences:

- **Demographic Data:** Basic respondent information including gender, age and educational background.
- **News Consumption Patterns:** Frequency and methods of news consumption, including preferred platforms and devices.
- **Content Format Preferences:** Attitudes toward short-form content and its potential impact on news engagement.
- **Trust and Reliability :** Measurements of trust in different news sources and verification behaviors, particularly regarding social media.

The findings from this initial survey provided valuable information which we used to plan and design our prototype.

B. Prototype Development

From the data of initial survey and some discussion, we decided to create a news aggregating mobile application with a scrolling-based User Interface (UI) for news content. Inspired by short-form content platforms like Instagram/Facebook reels, TikTok and YouTube Shorts, the news app will scrape articles from various sources and deliver them in short-form. Initially, we created a digital prototype using Figma and some editing.

The main features of our prototype inspired by these platforms were:

- 1) **Scrolling UI for Content:** A vertical swipe/scroll navigation of content that covers the entire screen of application. It features a smooth transition between posts with minimal loading indicators and continuously loads new content.
- 2) **Like/Dislike interaction for Personalized Algorithm:** A feature to like or dislike content which is used as an engagement signal to help tune a personalized recommendation algorithm. *Like* leads to similar future recommendations whereas *Dislike* helps to filter out unwanted content.
- 3) **Sharing Content:** A feature with multiple options (copy link, share to other platforms etc.) which allows users to share content with other users. It is also an engagement metric which can keep track of popularity of certain content.
- 4) **Saving/Bookmarking Content:** A feature to save content to user's collection for later viewing. It is a private list that allows user to quickly access saved content in the future through their profile collection.

C. User Feedback and Evaluation

After the initial prototype development, to gather more comprehensive feedback we implemented brainstorming session followed by a more structured survey with a smaller focus group.

1) **Brainstorming Session:** We brainstormed ideas among peers to get their feedback and thoughts on our prototype. We received qualitative data on our UI and features which we kept in mind during development of our application.

2) **User Evaluation and Feedback Survey:** We completed a prototype application that featured news in a short-form styled UI, the news content was scraped from three online sources of Nepalese news: Onlinekhabar, Ratopati and Setopati. We selected a small group of peers who actively used short-form content applications(N=15), letting them test out the application. After the test, they filled out a short survey that evaluated the system’s usability using **System Usability Scale (SUS)** [10]. We also asked additional questions about their overall experience and impressions about the application.

IV. FINDINGS

A. Findings of Initial Survey

For the initial survey, respondents were selected using convenience sampling. This survey aimed to get data about news consumption patterns, content format preferences and trust and reliability regarding news found on social media.

1) **Demographic Data:** 110 respondents participated in the initial survey, from various education backgrounds and ages.

Demographic Data of Respondents

Age Data		
Age	Number	Percentage
Gen-Z (17 – 27)	90	81.8%
Millennials (28 – 43)	17	15.5%
Gen-X (44 – 59)	3	2.7%
Gender Data		
Gender	Number	Percentage
Male	71	64.5%
Female	39	35.5%
Educational Background Data		
Education	Number	Percentage
School	5	4.5%
Undergraduate	77	70%
Graduate	24	21.8%
Post Graduate/PhD	4	3.7%

*Note: Actual age range of Gen-Z is 12-27, but we used 17 as the lower limit because it was the lowest age of respondents in our survey.

2) **News Consumption Patterns:** The survey included questions about news consumption platform preferences, like primary source of news (social media, legacy media and online news portals). We found that a majority of respondents used social media (75.5%) or online news portals (20.9%) to consume news. Only 2 respondents claimed to use television and newspaper as their primary

source of news. This further proved our research on decline of legacy media.

What is your primary source of news?
110 responses

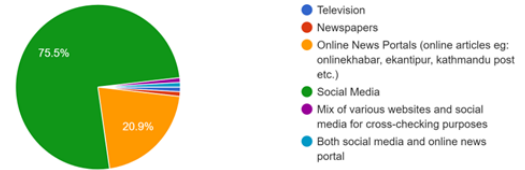


Fig. 1: News platform preference

The survey also included question about news consumption frequency based on a 5 point Likert scale. 1 being "Never" and 5 being "Daily", we found that a majority of respondents (67.3%) check for news updates fairly often (3,4,5).

How often do you check for News updates?
110 responses

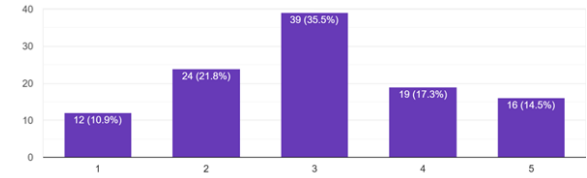


Fig. 2: News consumption frequency

3) **Content Format Preferences:** The survey revealed that a majority of respondents used short-form content applications very frequently, 50% rating 5 (Daily) and 26.4% rating 4 on the Likert scale for consumption frequency of short-form content. This data is in-line with our research on the rapid growth of short-form content platforms and their impact on the digital landscape.

How often do you consume short-form content (eg. TikTok videos, YouTube shorts, Instagram reels etc.)
110 responses

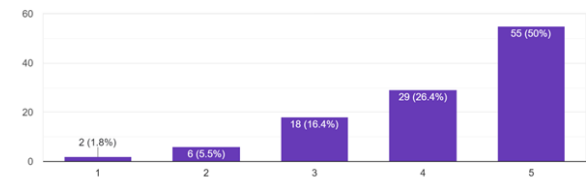


Fig. 3: Short-form content consumption frequency

A majority of the respondents also responded positively to the idea of short-form news.

A resounding 70% of respondents said they would prefer to receive news in short-form format.

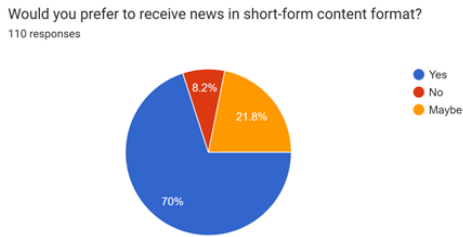


Fig. 4: Preference towards short-form news

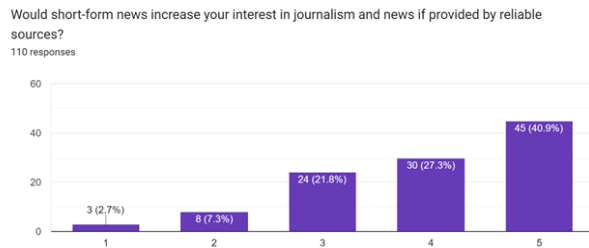


Fig. 5: Short-form news correlation with interest in journalism

A majority (68.2%) of respondents also agreed that short-form news would increase their interest in journalism as a whole. This data further proves how digital adaptation to modern trends can support news outlets and agencies to increase public reach and allow for more revenue generation.

- 4) **Trust and Reliability:** When asked on how trustworthy they found news found on social media, a majority of respondents (53.6%) were neutral. This is worrying for the state of journalism in Nepal, as respect and trust can be damaged due to unregulated social media news.

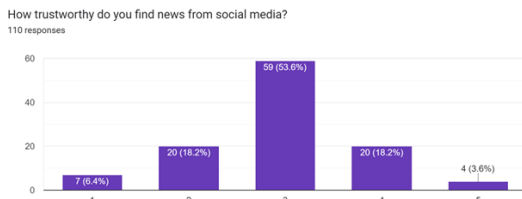


Fig. 6: Trust in social media regarding news

B. Findings of User Feedback and Evaluation

User feedback was taken from peers who actively used short-form content applications. 15 participants used our application featuring short-form content news and provided their

feedback. We used the System Usability Scale (SUS) to get usability evaluation of our application. The calculated average SUS score of our survey was 82.16.

- 1) **Engagement:** Users were very engaged with short-form news presented on the app with a majority(86%) of scores being 4 and 5 on the Likert scale. Majority of users also answered that they definitely would(60%) or were open to(26.7%) consume news in this format over other methods.

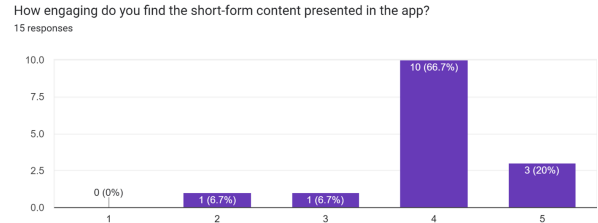


Fig. 7: Engagement score of short-form news content

Did you prefer to consume news in short-form format over other methods?

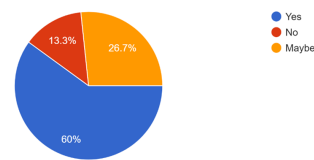


Fig. 8: Engagement score of short-form news content

- 2) **Favorite features:** On a checklist query of what features they liked the most, users were most happy with the scrolling UI of the application which loaded news content instantly while scrolling. Users also liked the read-more news redirect feature, which would quickly load the articles from their source websites locally in the application.

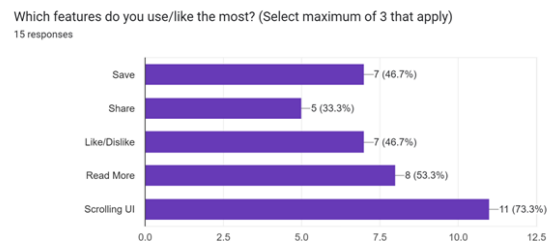


Fig. 9: Best features chosen by users

Overall, users praised the intuitive design of the application, which was similar to the short-form content format they were familiar with, while also being engaging for the purpose of

consuming news. They were positive towards the UI and implementation of features, and provided more valuable feedback as to what other features they would like to see. Some of these features are:

- Comment section for news articles to discuss and interact with other users
- News ranking system to see top-liked articles and interactions
- Daily highlights where summarized content of news can provide quick insights into whats currently happening

These features lean towards an application with more social media and online user interactivity oriented services, which seems to be the preference for Gen-Z users.

V. CONCLUSION

This study highlights the potential of short-form content in adapting journalism for Gen-Z in Nepal. Survey results and user feedback demonstrate a strong preference for this format, emphasizing its relevance in today's digital landscape. The development and evaluation of a prototype application reaffirm the feasibility of integrating short-form content into news content delivery strategies for younger audiences.

However, challenges remain in ensuring credibility, maintaining journalistic standards and providing financial sustainability. While this app's evaluation mainly targeted a Gen-Z audience, future work involves exploring the feasibility of this model for a more diverse audience of all ages and backgrounds. The integration of advanced personalization algorithms, more social-interactivity features, and monetization strategies can enhance this model further. As digital media continues to evolve, short-form content offers a promising avenue for journalism to engage younger audiences while preserving the core values of the profession.

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